

GALAXIES

Families of stars called galaxies, of all shapes and sizes, throng the Universe. Each galaxy is a giant star-city, composed of billions of stars, and often spectacular clouds of gas and dust as well. The Sun is just one of 400 billion stars making up our home galaxy, the Milky Way.

The core of a spiral galaxy consists of old stars

DATA FILE



GALAXIES IN OBSERVABLE UNIVERSE: More than 220 billion



SMALLEST KNOWN GALAXY: Segue 2, 200 light years across



LARGEST KNOWN GALAXY: IC 1101, about 6 million light years across



CLOSEST GALAXY: Canis Major Dwarf Galaxy, 42,000 light years away

Molecular clouds are dense patches of gas and dust